

“MEN, REMEMBER THERE IS NO RETREAT FROM HERE. YOU MUST DIE WHERE YOU STAND.”

Colin Campbell, Commander of the Highland Brigade, at the Battle of Balaclava, October 25, 1854

THE TENSIONS THAT HAD BEEN mounting between **Russia** and the **Ottoman Empire** in the previous year spilled over into a war. Britain and France joined the fight from October. The conflict was fueled by the decision of Czar Nicholas I (1796–1855) to declare the right to protect **Orthodox Christians** living under Ottoman rule. When this claim was rejected by the Ottomans, Nicholas sent troops into Moldavia and

The Crimean War

Brigadier Scarlett leads the British Heavy Brigade uphill at Balaclava, on October 25, 1854 against the Russians during the Crimean War.

Wallachia, and the Ottoman Empire declared war. By March 1854, Britain and France had also declared war on Russia, and in September they landed troops in Russia's **Crimea** territory and began a siege of **Sevastopol**. In October, a brigade of British troops at the **Battle of Balaclava** misinterpreted orders, charging down a valley instead of up it, allowing Russians to bombard the 673 soldiers on all sides. Had it not been for French intervention, the casualty rate would have been higher than 40 percent. This incident was memorialized in the poem by Lord Alfred Tennyson, *The Charge of the Light Brigade*.

Austria threatened to enter the war against Russia in 1856 and a preliminary peace was arranged on February 1, followed by the March 30 **Treaty of Paris**.

The Crimean War was the first conflict to be covered by newspapers, which were taking advantage of the new telegraphic and photographic technology. The war also established the reputation of the “**Lady with the Lamp**,” British nurse Florence Nightingale (1820–1910), whose reforms to field hospitals caused a dramatic reduction in deaths from disease during wartime. She helped promote nursing as a respectable career for women.



A painting of King Mongkut of Siam, who was also known as Rama IV.

MISSIONARY DAVID LIVINGSTONE

was exploring the interior of Africa (see 1849) on his second expedition. He was convinced a trade route to the sea existed, and sailed up the **Zambezi River** in November 1853 to find it. Two years later, he and his party came across a gigantic waterfall, known as **Mosi-oa-Tunya**, “the Smoke that Thunders.” He was the first European to see the falls and renamed them **Victoria Falls**.

To the East, in Siam (Thailand), King Mongkut (see 1851), known for his interest in the West, signed commercial agreements with Britain and the US in an effort to open up **Siamese** trade.



US filibuster William Walker surrenders to Costa Rican troops.

IN NICARAGUA, US-BORN WILLIAM

WALKER (1824–60), who had arrived in the country in 1855 with 58 men, declared himself **president**. He was initially invited by Francisco Castellón (1815–55), who had been trying to organize a liberal revolt. This was a period of **filibustering**: attempts by privately funded mercenaries to take over small countries and annex them to the US. Walker intended to establish Nicaragua as a **slave state**; southern US states wanted to enlarge slave-holding territory as abolitionism grew. Walker was eventually captured by invading Costa Rican forces and later shot.



Boers establish the **Orange Free State** in South Africa

March 31 Treaty of Kanagawa trade agreement signed between Japan and US

World's first oil well drilled in **Poland**

Canadian geologist **Abraham Pineo Gesner** invents process for extracting **kerosene** from coal

November 17 Suez Canal company formed in Egypt

February 11 Kassa Hailu crowned Tewodros II, emperor of Ethiopia

David Livingstone is first European to see “**Victoria Falls**,” as he renames them

March 30 Treaty of Paris settles Crimean War

William Walker (1827–60) proclaims himself president of Nicaragua; tries to establish slave plantations

March 3 First telegraph line in Australia opens

US chemist **Benjamin Silliman** is first to distill **petroleum**

Umar Tall (1797–1864) conquers and controls Upper Niger and Senegal basins, West Africa

October 25 Battle of Balaclava in Crimean War; fatal charge made by British cavalry

March 17 Taiping army of 350,000 invades Anhui, eastern China, during **Taiping Rebellion**

English engineer **Henry Bessemer** (1813–98) invents process for **mass production of steel**

Second Opium War (to 1860) over trade between China and Britain